had scheduled assembly elections in five states starting end of March and running in multiple phases all the way until the end of April. As discussed earlier in the book, even before the Bihar elections, the EC had held an all-party meet to consider substituting traditional modes of campaigning with e-rallies. While the BJP had already hopped on to the idea with the home minister having held successful e-rallies already in the state, the idea was heavily opposed by all opposition parties including the Congress. Eventually, the EC had to cave and allow physical rallies to take place. During the upcoming polls as well, all political parties held huge rallies in all five states going in for the polls: Tamil Nadu, Assam, West Bengal, Kerala and Puducherry with zero effort to substitute them with e-rallies. With the ruling Trinamool Congress government led by Mamata Banerjee for two terms wanting to retain power and the BJP intending to make large inroads in the state, West Bengal became a political battleground. For reasons outside the scope of this book, it was crucial for the BJP to acquire a solid footing in the state which had very little presence of the party up until now. West Bengal shares a very porous border with Bangladesh, Bhutan and Nepal and a general belief is that a lot of undocumented immigration takes place through it, bringing problems of smuggling of illegal substances and unwanted miscreants. On top of that, corruption and misgovernance had been plaguing the state for decades, obstructing large investment and economic progress to bring it at par with the other large Indian states.

Political atmosphere during the campaign remained charged up, with parties inviting huge mask-less crowds to their rallies. The prime minister too held several rallies which attracted massive crowds. Top leaders of all competing parties participated in extensive campaigning across the five states. These political rallies which saw absolutely no COVID-19-appropriate behaviour being followed turned into super-spreader events. The new mutations found breeding grounds and endangered the country's fight against the virus. Naturally, the already rising graph of COVID-19 cases acquired speed, quickly reaching a point that overwhelmed the country's healthcare systems.

The political rallies, especially those conducted by the prime minister, received great ire. Despite all political leaders campaigning, it was the prime minister who the people held accountable and rightfully so, since he is India's premier leader. They blamed him for being callous and taking his